Managing Communications
(Chapter 8 in textbook)

Trimester 2.2025

Communication

- The transition of information and understanding through the use of common symbols from one person or group to another
- The exchange of ideas, emotions, messages, stories and information through different discursive means
- Can be verbal or nonverbal

Elements of Communication Process

Theories of Communication

- **Organizational behavior (OB)**
  - the study of how people interact within groups in a workplace setting
  - **Emphases in OB**
    1. Culture
    2. Human relations
    3. Power
    4. Discourse theory

Cultural Emphasis

- Communication is influenced by the cultural norms, values, and practices of the organization and individual backgrounds.
- Communicating produces and shares common meanings and interpretations
- E.g. organizational language, jargons.

Cultural Emphasis

The patient's ***BP*** is stable at 120/80."

"We have a ***Code Blue*** in Room 302!"

Get the patient to surgery, ***stat***!"

"BoM" (Bill of Materials)

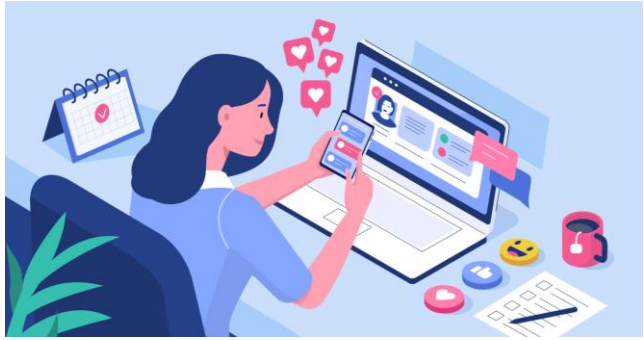
"Redline"

"Fail-safe"

Cultural Emphasis (Example)

Marketing

"We want the packaging to have a strong ***visual identity***. The matte finish with green accents supports our ***brand equity*** and reinforces the ***eco-premium positioning***. If we go for an embossed logo, it enhances ***brand recall*** — that's critical for shelf visibility."



Finance

I understand the ***branding ROI***, but the matte laminate and embossing push ***our per-unit cost*** up by 12%. Given our ***gross margin targets*** and ***break-even analysis***, that design might not be financially viable. We need a ***cost–benefit justification*** before approving any upgrades.

Production

From an operations standpoint, the embossing means retooling our ***die-cut molds*** and adjusting the ***machine calibration***. That affects our ***production lead time*** and ***throughput efficiency***. We'd also need to run ***quality assurance tests*** to make sure the packaging meets ***heat-resistance*** standards.

Human Relations Emphasis

- Focuses on the importance of social relationships, employee well-being, and motivation in the workplace
- Understand how **interpersonal relationship**, **communication** and **supportive work environment** influence employee satisfaction, performance, organizational effectiveness
- E.g., townhall meetings, direct communications with management

Power Emphasis

- Communication as a medium to influence and recruit others towards preferred views and interests
- How power dynamics, authority, and influence shape communication, decision-making and interpersonal relationships within organizations
- Organizational politics
  - e.g. lobbying for resources, building alliances, managing information

Discourse Theory

- Discourse: structured ways of speaking and writing
- Examines how language, communication, and social interactions shape organizational structures, norms, and identities.
- Eg.
  - Employees as “family”
  - Employee as a “resource” vs. “person”

Levels of Communication

- **4 levels of communication:**
  1. Dyadic communication
  2. Small-group communication
  3. Organizational communication
  4. Mass communication

Dyadic Communication

- Two-party communication
- Interpersonal communication:
  - the direct interaction between two or more people
  - verbal or non-verbal
  - formal or informal

Small-Group Communication

- Roles are established
- Subgroups formed
- Specific dynamic created between members
- Groupthink

Organizational Communication

- **Four directions:**

1. Downward
2. Upward
3. Horizontal
4. Diagonal

Organizational Communication

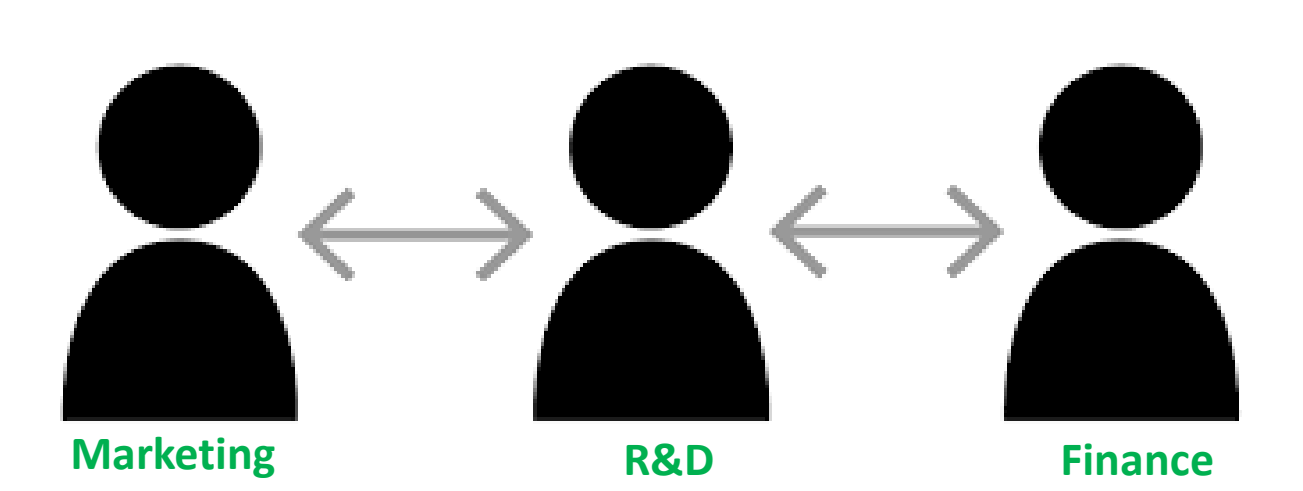
- **Downward communication**: flow of communication from superior to subordinate
  - **Functions:**

Organizational Communication

- **Upward communication**: flow of communication from subordinates to superiors

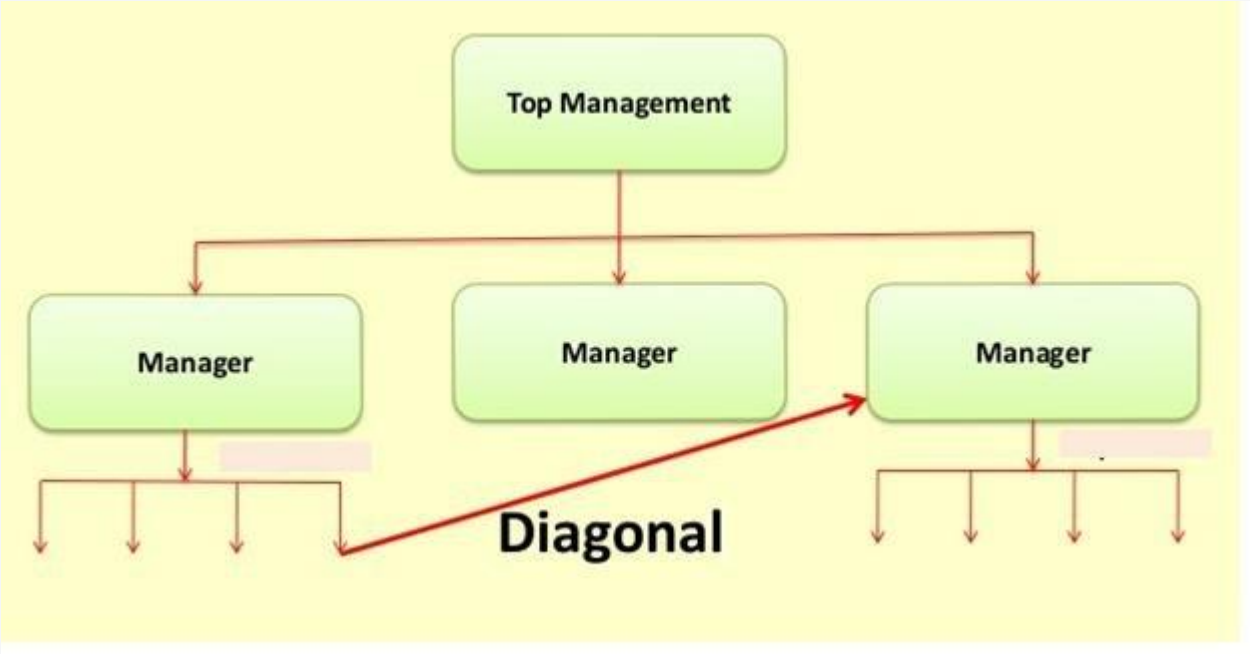
Organizational Communication

- **Horizontal communication**: communication between different departments



Organizational Communication

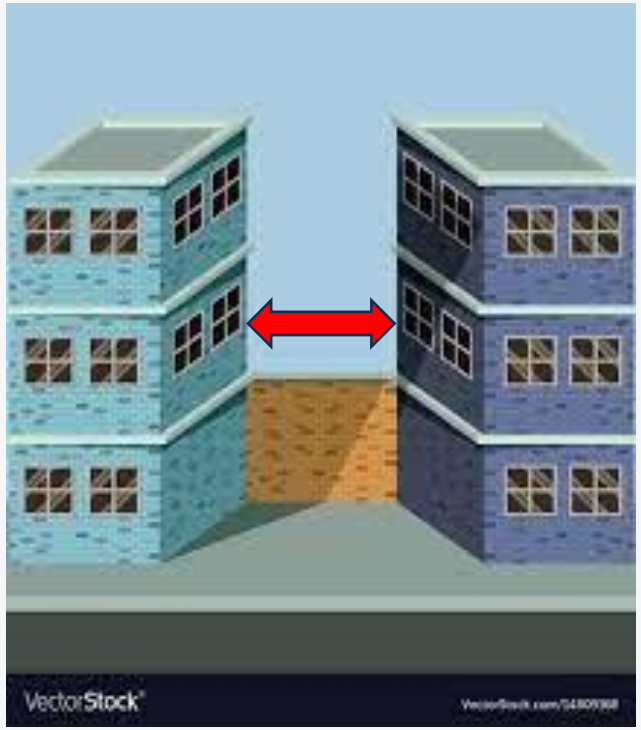
- **Diagonal communication**: communication between different levels and functional areas



Audiences

- **3 main audiences receive organizational communication**
  1. **Internal audiences** (employees) through *intraorganizational communication*
  2. **Other organizations** (partners, suppliers, etc.) through *interorganizational communication*
  3. **Wider society** (markets, society, press, etc.) through *mass communication*

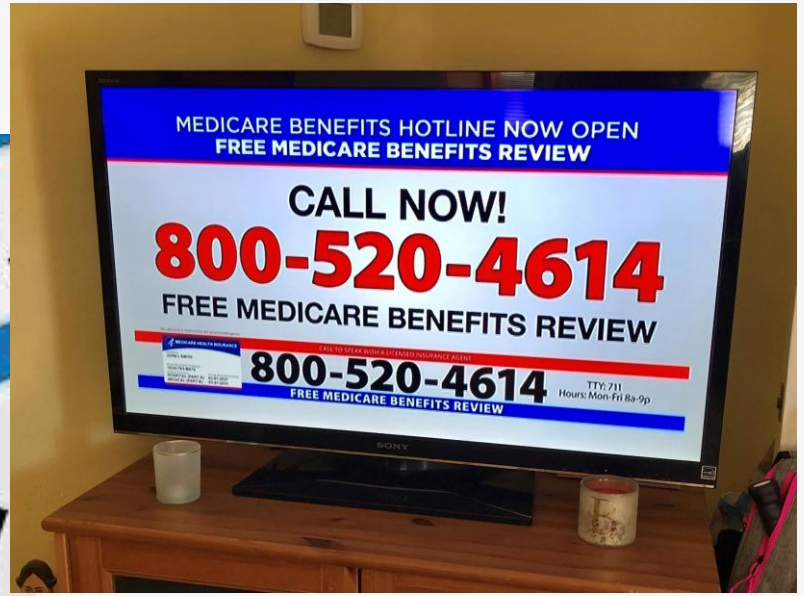
Interorganizational Communication



- Organizations working together need lots of coordination, cooperation and bargaining
- E.g.
  - car manufacturer communicates with suppliers (tire or engine parts)
  - hospital collaborates with pharmaceutical company to run clinical trial

Mass Communication

- Communication from one point to many receivers
- Eg. TV ads, billboards, websites, etc.



Information Richness

The amount of information that can be transmitted in an effective manner

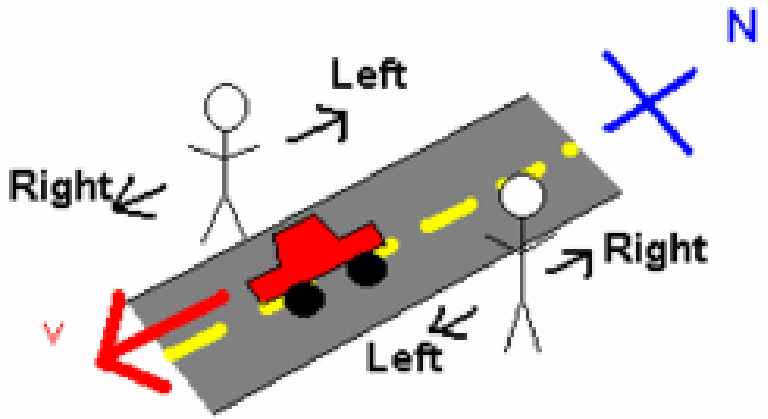
Media	Richness	Example	Benefit
Face-to-face	Very high	Ask supervisor for a raise.	Ability to adjust message according to real-time feedback.
Telephone conversation, video conference	High	Meeting with virtual group members.	Efficient, less costly, and less time-consuming than traveling to a central location.
Memos, letters, personalized e-mail, voice mail	Low	Communicate a company service policy to a customer.	Efficient and cost-effective way to communicate routine information.
General e-mail, financial reports, flyers, bulletin boards, computer reports	Very low	Annual report to shareholders.	Standardized information for large audience.

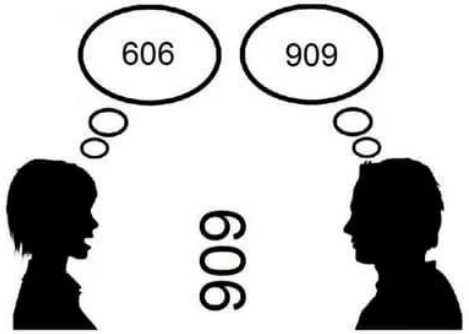
Barriers to Effective Communication

- Frame of reference
- Selective listening
- Value judgments
- Source credibility
- Filtering
- In-group language
- Status differences
- Time pressures
- Communication overload

Barriers: Frame of Reference

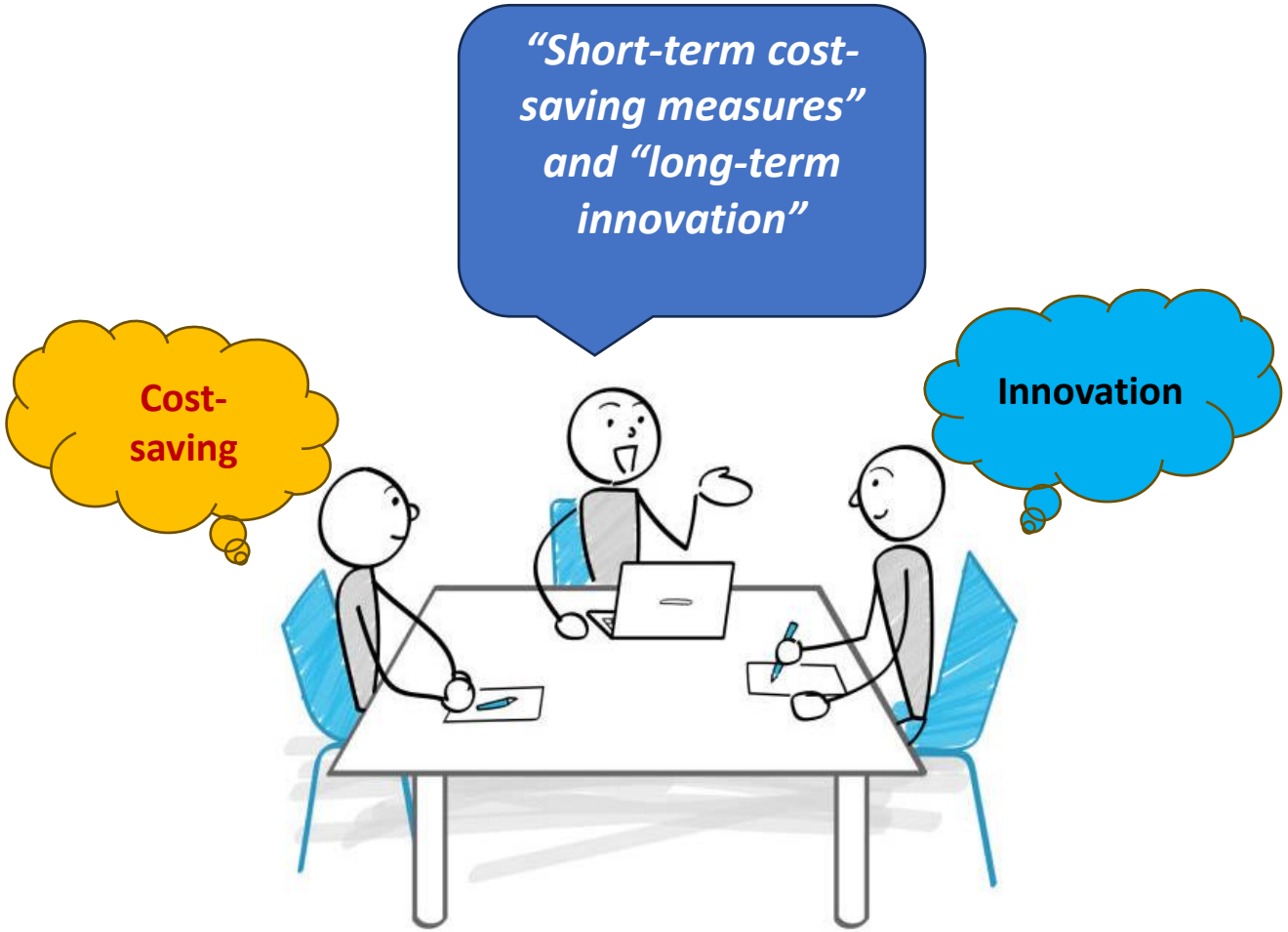
- Different individuals can interpret the same communication differently depending on their previous experience
- When the encoding and decoding processes are not alike, communication tends to break down





Barriers: Selective Listening

A form of selective perception in which we tend to block out new information, especially if it conflicts with what we believe



Barriers: Value Judgments

- Involves the receiver assigning an overall worth to a message before receiving the entire communication
- May be based on the receiver's evaluation of the communicator or previous experiences with the communicator
- E.g. *When a new intern suggests an idea, a senior member responds, "That's unrealistic."*

Barriers: Source Credibility

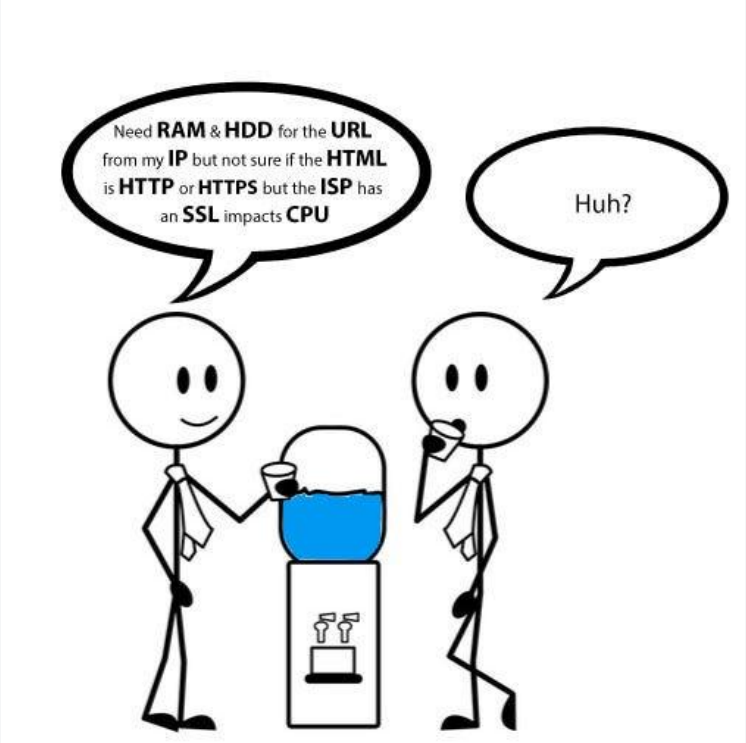
- The trust, confidence, and faith that the receiver has in the words and actions of the communicator
- Based on expertise, trustworthiness, confidence, etc.
- Eg. *A manager with poor track record gives motivational talk.*

Barriers: Filtering

- The manipulation of information so that the receiver perceives it as positive
- Common occurrence is **upward communication** in organizations
  - subordinates cover up unfavorable information in messages to their superiors
  - may be due to superior being tough, aggressive, quick to fire employees, intimidating

Barriers: In-Group Language

- Technical jargons
- Company
- Occupation, profession, social groups
- Can provide members with feelings of belonging, cohesiveness, and self-esteem

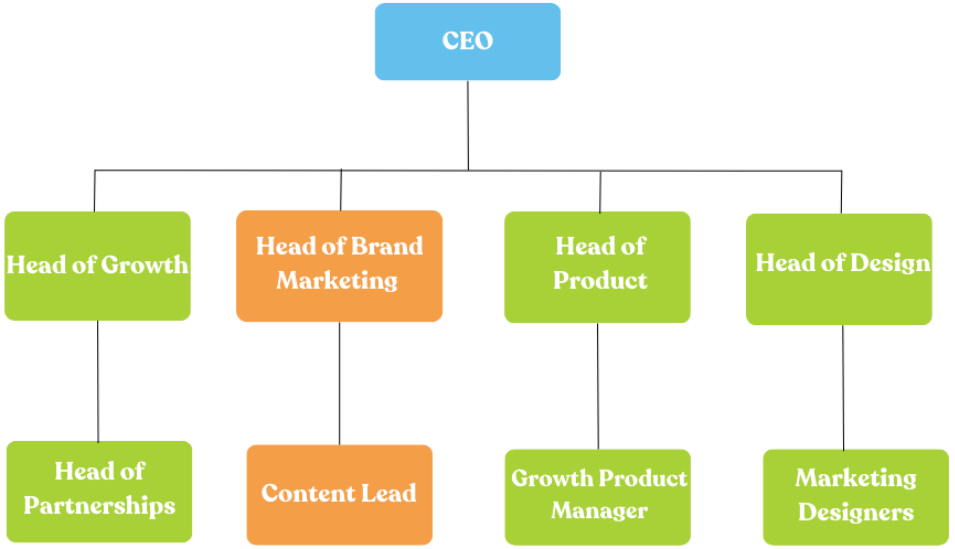


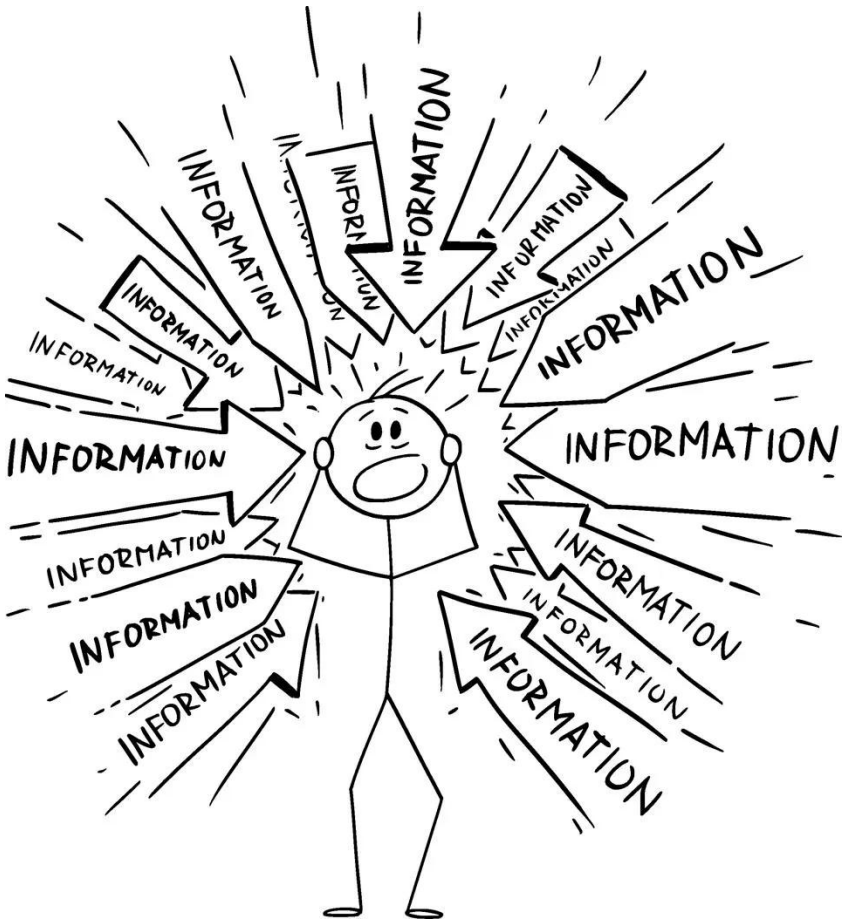
Barriers: Status Differences

- Status differences can be perceived as threats by persons lower in the hierarchy
- E.g. A CEO's suggestion is interpreted as an order

Barriers: Time Pressures

- Managers do not have the time to communicate frequently with every subordinate
- *Short-circuiting:* leaving someone out of the formal channel of communication who normally would be included
- Eg. CEO sends a quick, one-line email to all departments: “Launch moved to Friday”



Barriers: Communication Overload

- “Information Era” or the “Age of Information”
- Managers cannot absorb or adequately respond to all the messages directed to them
  - “screen out” the majority of messages, and are never decoded